EVERYDAY MILLIONAIRES

Neither Karen nor Walter came from money; in fact, both of their families struggled to make ends meet when they were young. Karen’s parents worked to support their own family of five as well as Karen's father's mother and sister. Those expenses taxed Karen's dad's salary from the post office and Karen’s mom’s income as a nurse, but Karen says she was never without the essentials like food and clothes. Walter, on the other hand, grew up in an especially poor home, and he went to work at age fourteen to help support his family. Despite the financial struggles, both families impressed the importance of giving on their children. In fact, Karen said her parents gave her two checks every birthday. One check was for Karen to write to herself to purchase something she wanted. The other check was for Karen to write out to a charity of her choice. This powerful lesson turned her into a lifelong giver and always ensured Karen had a heart of gratitude no matter how much money she had.

Walter and Karen were high school sweethearts and dated for years while they both completed college and graduate degrees. With little family financial support, the pair still managed to avoid student loans, paying for school with cash, grants, and scholarships. This set them up to win big-time as they launched into their careers. Karen got a job in health administration and Walter began his career as a CPA. Having grown up with so little, both were naturally frugal and never got caught up in the need to impress other people. They lived simple but fulfilling lives, making giving a priority, avoiding all debt except a mortgage, and raising their two children with a firm understanding of how to manage money.

The couple took advantage of company retirement plans as soon as they started working. That early start, they say, was the main factor that led to their wealth today. Walter and Karen never received an inheritance, never lived a flashy life, never bought more than they needed, never spent more than they made, and always made giving and saving their top priorities. Along the way, they paid off their mortgage more than ten years early, sent two kids to college debt-free, bought a condo for their kids to live in while in college, and invested consistently throughout their entire careers. Today, all that hard work has paid off, as the couple is sitting on a net worth of $6.1 million.

“I don’t think our kids realize what we’re worth,” Karen says. “We don’t even consider ourselves wealthy.” That’s something we heard over and over again from the millionaires we studied. Despite the myths you hear and the depictions you see on TV, most millionaires are low-key, keeping their wealth under the radar. Walter and Karen don’t need to flash their wealth to impress other people, and they aren’t in a race to spend it all before they die. Instead, they’re doing what they’ve always done—taking care of their families, giving to causes they care about, and investing their time into local charities. They also remain committed to their marriage, spending three to four months a year traveling and experiencing the world together.

Typical millionaires—people like Walter and Karen—aren’t trying to keep up with anyone else, and they don’t care about impressing people. They’re just living their lives, taking care of themselves and their families, and quietly serving other people. That’s why most of their neighbors would be